

# Student Politics as a Pathway to Parliament:

*A Case Study from the University of Iceland, 1931–2024*

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## **ABSTRACT:**

Political pathways into national office shape who becomes part of the political elite and whose interests and experiences are represented in democratic institutions. This study provides the first empirical examination of whether leadership in student politics at the University of Iceland is associated with subsequent entry into parliament between 1931 and 2024. Using an original longitudinal dataset of 856 student political leaders, compiled from archived student newspapers and parliamentary records, the study analyzes parliamentary entry through logistic regression and Cox proportional hazards models. The results present evidence of a systematic relationship, suggesting that student politics may serve as an early-stage pathway into national office. Of the 856 individuals subject to analysis, 67 entered Alþingi at some point, at any capacity, between 1931 and 2025, yielding a total parliamentary entry rate of 7.8%, substantially higher than the estimated 0.34% parliamentary participation in the general population. Cohort effects dominate the results, with later cohorts generally less likely to enter parliament and tending to do so later than those in the earliest cohort. Associations and gender do not display a consistent statistically significant relationship with parliamentary entry in the multivariable models. The findings suggest that student politics at the University of Iceland functioned as a pathway into national political office during the period of analysis.

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# **1 Theoretical Introduction**

Political pathways into national office determine not only who becomes part of the political elite but, more importantly, whose interests, experiences, and social backgrounds are represented in democratic institutions, whereas if political recruitment is systematically skewed toward certain classes, policy is likely to reflect that (Carnes 2015, 213-221). Who gets into office determines who is in the position to act, exercise judgment, and be responsive within the system (Pitkin 1967); it shapes advocacy, agenda-setting, and ultimately political inequality (Phillips 1998). If access to office is structured by early organizational areas such as student politics, then political recruitment may reproduce broader inequalities in political voice and representation rather than simply reflect equal democratic opportunity.

Understanding political pathways has thus been a core question of the field of political participation, and is examined in this study through the case of the Nordic island nation of Iceland, which, through its institutional simplicity, gives a unique opportunity to observe, over a long period, a political career pathway from student politics to national office. Due to its small population, this pathway is effectively condensed to movement between two central institutions: the University of Iceland (UI) and the national parliament, Alþingi. Although other universities have emerged in Iceland since the UI's establishment in 1911, the UI has retained a dominant position with regard to program selection and student enrollment, meaning that, historically, most student political activity has occurred within this institution. Similarly, within Iceland's parliamentary system, participation in national politics goes almost exclusively through Alþingi.

Student politics at the UI have long served as an early arena for political participation, where students are exposed to campaigning, elections, committee work, and debates over a wide range of (mainly student-related) issues. Despite the visibility of student politics in Icelandic

public life, no previous study has systematically examined whether participation in student politics at the UI constitutes a meaningful pathway to national political office. By constructing an original longitudinal dataset of student political leaders between 1931 and 2024, this study provides the first empirical examination of this pathway by exploring the following research question: To what extent is leadership in student politics at the UI associated with subsequent entry into parliament between 1931 and 2024?

The results present evidence of a systematic relationship, suggesting that student politics may function as an early-stage pathway into national office. Although the present study does not directly test the causal mechanisms underlying the relationship, the literature provides several plausible explanations for why such a pathway may exist, including political self-selection, civic skill acquisition, and network formation.

Student politics may attract those who already have an inclination towards political participation. This pattern would be consistent with Max Weber's ([1919] 1946) distinction between those who “live for” and “live off” politics. In this view, student politics can be understood as a platform where engagement is not materially dependent but rather driven by an inner sense of commitment, ambition, or interest. For those who do participate, the returns may include resources that could help facilitate a path to parliament, e.g., political experience, networks, and civic skills, however, participation is time-consuming, the field is often competitive, and there is no immediate financial incentive.

Although acknowledging this potential selection bias, it is important to note that the resources gained from participation have been attributed to political participation (Verba et al. 2002; Norris & Lovenduski 1995) and political success (Bull 2012, 61-74). Among the most important of these resources are civic skills, which are developed through the core institutions of

socialization, such as the family, the educational system, and voluntary associations (Verba et al. 2002).

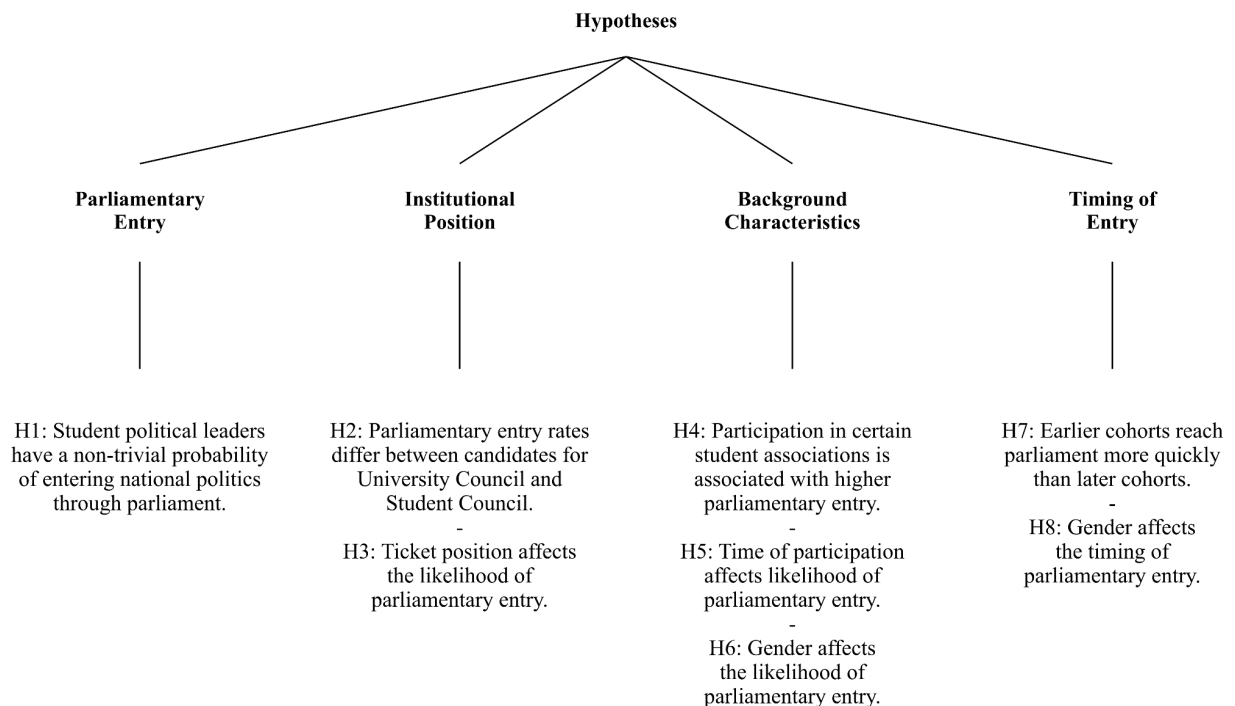
Civic skills are gained throughout our lives, and the power of them is such that those who possess a strong vocabulary, have experience communicating in both written and spoken language, know how to formulate an argument, and are experienced in public speaking or organizing should feel more confident about taking on political activities (Verba et al. 2002). As with any other skill, they can be trained and honed through practice and exposure, and for aspiring politicians, these are a great advantage for effectively communicating ideas and decisions and convincing their political party and constituency of their merit (Bull 2012, 61-74).

While different in nature, both main phases of participation provide forms of political experience that may function as a resource for aspiring politicians alongside civic skills and social networks (Norris and Lovenduski 1995). Through electoral participation, students are exposed to campaigning and situations that require justifying their positions, and those elected to council face committee and organizational work that may require communication and negotiation skills. Participation may also facilitate network formation, as students inevitably establish political and social ties with peers, university officials, and, at times, high-level political actors. Student representatives at the UI have semi-frequent interactions with ministers and other senior political figures, as well as university administrators (Erla Björg Gunnarsdóttir 2013; Morgunblaðið 2004; Morgunblaðið 2023; Ríkisútvarpið 2011; Vísir 2009; Ólafur Pálsson 2026).

The pathway is not isolated within the context of Iceland, but a 2011 report by the Equality and Human Rights Commission on pathways to politics in the UK found that at least 19% of British politicians engaged in student politics, which was seen to help develop confidence, experience, and contacts that the individuals utilized in national party politics

(Durose et al. 2011). And more broadly, youth political organizations have frequently been described as entry points into political careers (Recchi 1999, 107–24).

Taken together, the literature suggests that student politics may function both as a site of political self-selection and as an environment in which politically relevant resources, experience, and networks are developed. Based on these expectations, several hypotheses are tested using data collected from a variety of archived student newspapers and public records on current and former parliamentarians in Iceland from 1931 to 2024.



## 2 Methods

### 2.1 Data Description and Collection

The data used to test the above hypotheses is an original dataset consisting of 1387 unique observations, each representing a leader in student politics at the University of Iceland between 1931 and 2024. Candidates were differentiated based on whether they ran for the Student Council or the University Council. The Student Council primarily functions as a representative body focused on student affairs and student interests, while the University Council incorporates student representatives into the larger governance structure of the university alongside faculty and administrators (Háskóli Íslands 2026; Stúdentaráð Háskóla Íslands 2026).

Determining which of these participants in student politics are considered “leaders” proved a tricky task due to significant changes in voting and participation structures over the years. Notably, from 1960 to 1973, there was a change in the voting procedures, moving from association-based ticket voting to individual candidate voting. To include these years in the analysis, the elected Student Council members for each year are included, rather than the top five candidates on each association's ticket. In 1974, the system reverted to the original ticket-voting system; however, in 2013, the voting system changed again, from a single ticket from each association across all departments to specialized tickets for each of the university's five departments. For this period, only the top candidate on each department's ticket is included. With these considerations, the following criteria for a student leader were determined:

**Table 1. Operational Criteria for Inclusion as a Student Political Leader**

|                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Top 5 candidates for Student Council from any student association, 1936–59, 1974–2012. |
| 2. Top candidate for University Council from any student association, 1936–59, 1974–2024. |

- 
3. Top candidate in each of the five departments of the university for the Student Council, from any student association, 2013–2024.
- 
4. Member of Student Council 1931–1935, 1960–1973.
- 
5. *Member of the board of any student association, 1931–2024.*
- 

Additionally to categories 1 through 4, which were candidates for either the Student or University Councils, members of student association boards were included as student leaders. This group is limited in the dataset due to the scarcity of information on board members' activities over the years. It was initially included as Vaka (the longest running association) has a complete list of board members since 1935; however, it is the only association with that information. Röskva, established in 1988, has a complete list of chairmen on its website since its founding year, but that is all. Individuals who fit only this category are excluded from the analysis due to concerns about selection bias.

Prior to this study, there was no existing list or database consisting of members of student politics at the University of Iceland. The collection process began after settling on the above criteria for student leaders and was mostly manual. It involved reviewing news articles and archived student papers to gather complete information for each year. However, due to the nature of archival data collection, there are a handful of years missing from the period of analysis, either fully (1961, 1963, 1965, 1969, 1970, 1971, 1973, 1990, 1991, 1992, 2009, and 2010) or partially (1989, 2004, 2005, 2007, 2008, and 2011). Despite this patchiness, the cohorts remain relatively similar in size, ranging from 248 to 332 individuals.

Several key variables were collected on these individuals: the student association they were a member of (when available), their year of participation in student politics, their ticket position (when applicable), their position served on association board (when applicable), whether



they were a candidate for Student Council, University Council, both, or neither, and their gender. In addition to variables related to activities in student politics, we collected information on whether an individual is now or has ever been a member of parliament, if so, what year they entered, which political party they were a member of, and whether they served as a minister in government.

The main source of information on parliamentary participation was the page *“Biographies of Members of Parliament from 1845”* on the official Alpingi website, which allows for searching MPs by name. Using name searches, pictures, years, biographical information on education, and common sense, it was determined whether the student leader had gone on to become an MP, defined as someone who has taken a seat in Alpingi at any capacity, elected or substitutional. For cautionary reasons, individuals were excluded if there was sufficient doubt about identity matches.

## 2.2 Data Processing

The initial count of observations was 1723, but it was inflated by duplicate records of student leaders. For individuals appearing multiple times, observations were collapsed to the individual level, where those who had participated in student politics over several years had their most recent year of activity retained, while those who held several board positions retained their highest-ranking position, determined by the following hierarchy:

**Table 2. Board Position Hierarchy Used in Data Processing**

|                                        |
|----------------------------------------|
| 1. Chairman                            |
| 2. Vice Chairman / Lead Candidate      |
| 3. Secretary / Treasurer               |
| 4. Deputy Secretary / Deputy Treasurer |

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5. Editor / Editorial Board

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6. Representatives / Directors

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7. Board Member

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A candidate's highest ticket position held was retained; if they had been a candidate for both the Student and University Council, both were recorded; and if an individual was associated with two different student associations, the more recent one was recorded. After weeding out unwanted duplicates, the observations stand at 1387. However, as noted earlier, to isolate individuals who actively participated in electoral student politics, individuals who had never been candidates for either council but had only served on a student association board were excluded, resulting in a final sample of 856 unique individuals.

When it comes to student associations, only a few have maintained a level of consistency throughout the analysis period, namely Vaka (1935–2024) and Röskva (1988–2024), with earlier predecessors. For that reason, Félag vinstrimanna and Félag umbótasinna were merged with Röskva into “Röskva and predecessors,” Vaka remained unchanged, and the rest were combined into “Other.”

## 3 Results

### 3.1 Descriptive Results

#### 3.1.1 Sample Composition

Before proceeding to the analysis results, it is important to examine the sample composition, the representation of background variables, and consistency across the period of analysis. As not every year is represented in the sample, observations were aggregated to the decade and cohort levels. While counts at the decade level vary (ranging from 48 to 249), further aggregation into broader cohorts of 30-40 years, levels out the distribution. At which, the data shows a gradual increase over time with no extreme imbalance.

**Table 3. Sample Composition by Decade and Cohort**

| <b><i>Decades</i></b> |     |
|-----------------------|-----|
| 1930s                 | 56  |
| 1940s                 | 101 |
| 1950s                 | 91  |
| 1960s                 | 53  |
| 1970s                 | 74  |
| 1980s                 | 149 |
| 1990s                 | 94  |
| 2000s                 | 106 |
| 2010s                 | 84  |
| 2020s                 | 48  |
| Total                 | 856 |
| <b><i>Cohorts</i></b> |     |
| 1930s–1950s           | 248 |
| 1960s–1980s           | 276 |
| 1990s–2020s           | 332 |
| Total                 | 856 |

*Source: Data compiled by author*

Beyond the time variable, there are limited background variables for the sample population; the main ones being the student association they were part of and gender. While Vaka and Röskva (and predecessors) account for the majority of the sample (at 68.23%), a substantial portion of observations were part of other associations (at 23.01%), and there were a few who lacked that information and were assigned “Unknown” (at 8.76%).

**Table 4. Sample Composition by Student Association**

|                         |     |        |
|-------------------------|-----|--------|
| Vaka                    | 303 | 35.40% |
| Röskva and predecessors | 281 | 32.83% |
| Other                   | 197 | 23.01% |
| Unknown                 | 75  | 8.76%  |
| Total                   | 856 | 100%   |

*Source: Data compiled by author*

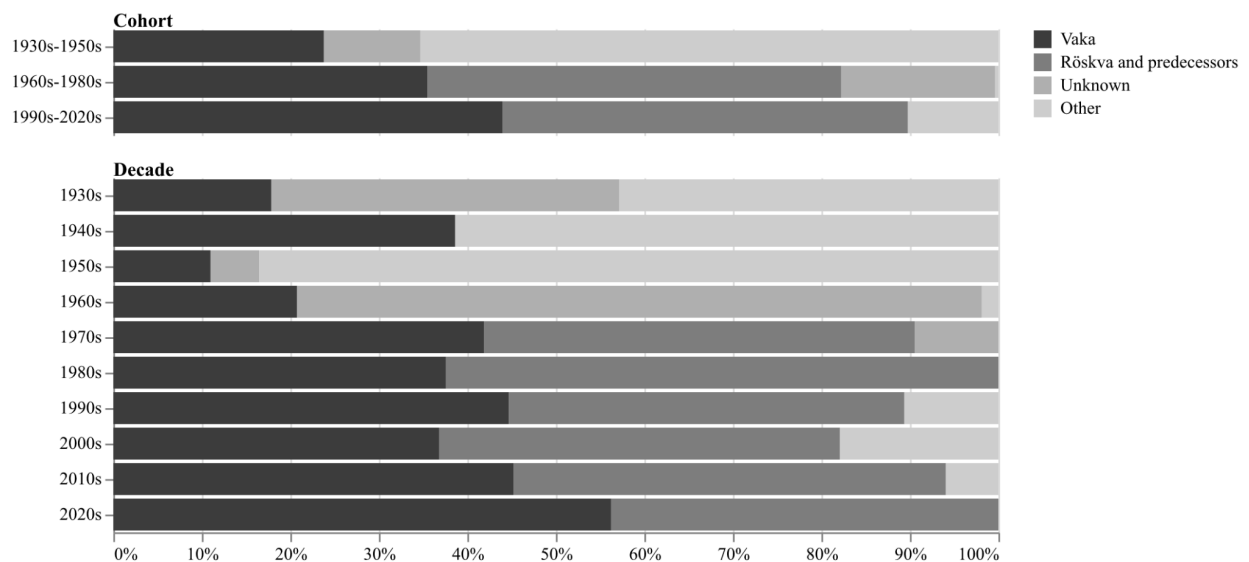
As illustrated in Figure 1, the earlier decades are the main drivers of the other, and unknown values, with a large majority of observations in the 1930s–1950s cohort falling into these groups. This is explained by the fact that in 1960, in response to criticism that representatives in the student council were too ideologically driven, spending too much time on local and world affairs, and not enough on student-specific problems, a decision was made to abolish the ticket voting system and revert to individual candidate voting confined to each of the four departments of the university (Höskuldur Jónsson 1960). The ticket voting system was originally implemented in 1936, a move away from individual candidate voting that had been in

force since the establishment of the student council in 1920 (Birgir Ísl. Gunnarsson 1960). This system lasted until 1973 when ticket voting was adopted once again (Stúdentablaðið 1974).

As mentioned before, the data-collection method was changed for the periods of individual candidate voting, where those who had been elected into the student council were collected, as there was no readily available data on who was a candidate or which association (if any) the representatives were a part of. This explains the “Unknown” in the 1960s and 1970s.

The absence of “Röskva and its predecessors” in the earlier cohort and decades is explained by the fact that the associations were not established until 1974.

**Figure 1. Temporal Changes in Student Association Representation**



*Source: Data compiled by author*

A majority of the sample were men at 591 (69.04%), while women were 265 (30.96%). This discrepancy can largely be attributed to the unequal tertiary educational participation

between the genders in the 20th century, where men maintained a significant majority of the student population in the earlier part of the analysis period.

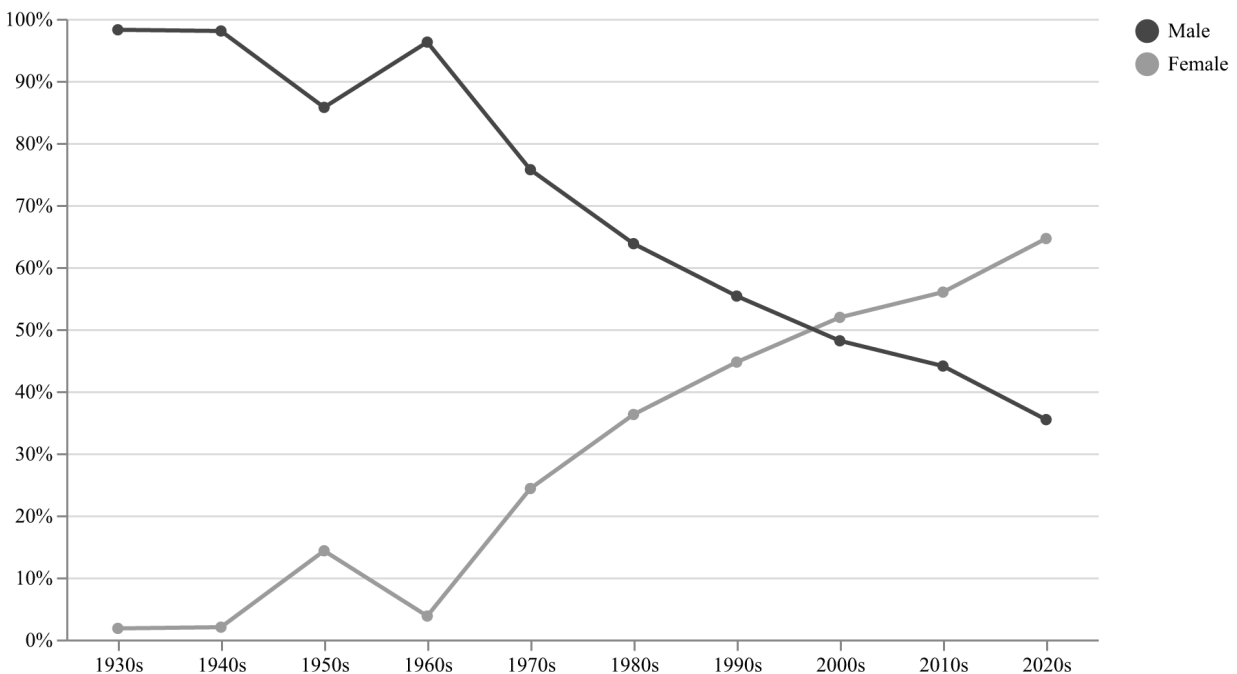
**Table 5. Gender Composition of Student Political Leaders**

|        |     |        |
|--------|-----|--------|
| Male   | 591 | 69.04% |
| Female | 265 | 30.96% |
| Total  | 856 | 100%   |

*Source: Data compiled by author*

However, as illustrated in Figure 2, the gap between the proportions of male and female student leaders by decade shrank relatively steadily up until the 2000s, when it diverged, with student leaders increasingly becoming female.

**Figure 2. Changes in the Gender Distribution of Student Leaders Over Time**



*Source: Data compiled by author*

### 3.1.2 Parliamentary Entry Rates

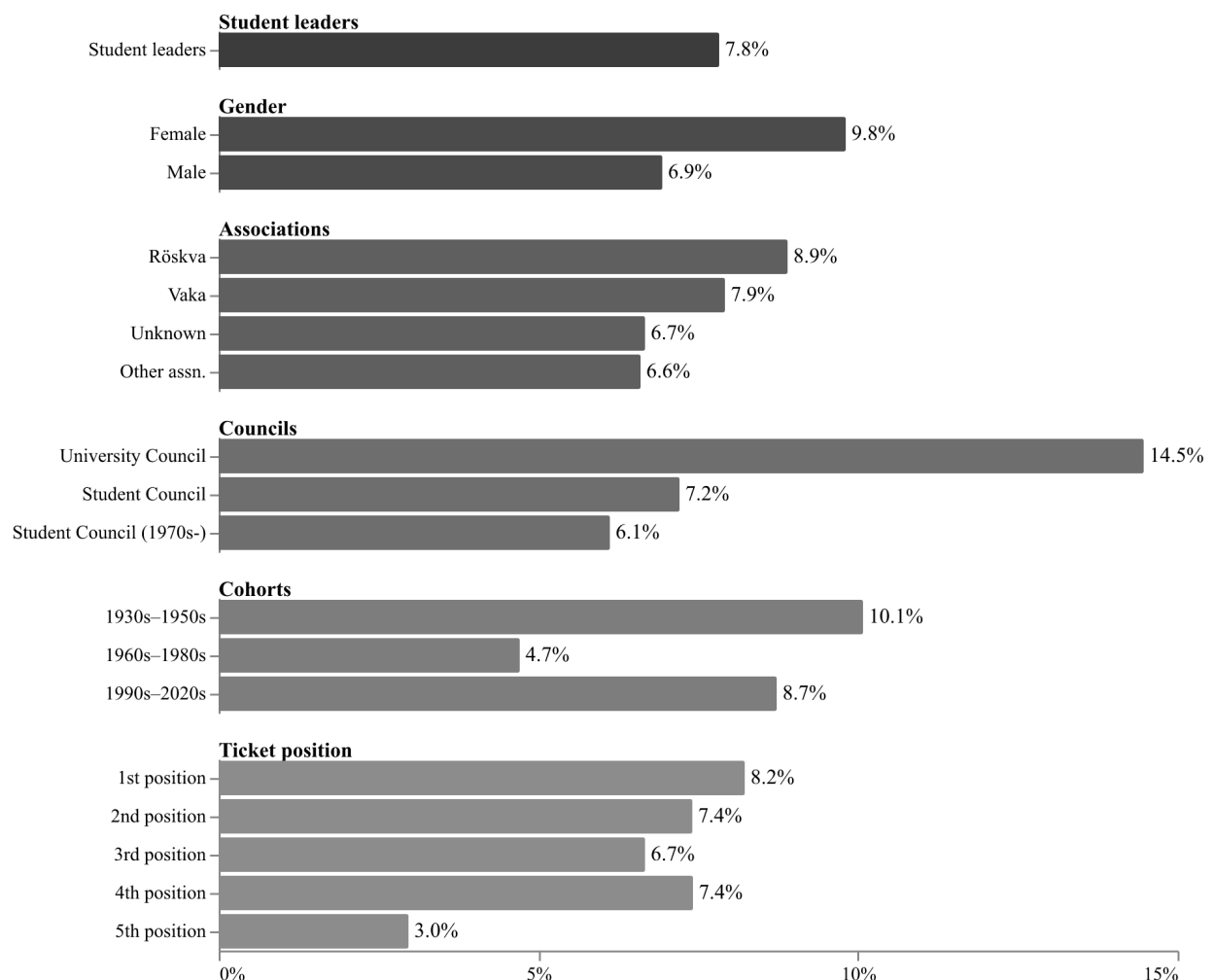
Of the 856 individuals subject to analysis, 67 entered Alþingi at some point, at any capacity, between 1931 and 2025, yielding a total parliamentary entry rate of 7.8%. As the sample lacks a true comparison, the number of all Icelandic citizens alive at any point from 1931 to 2024 who reached the age of 18 was estimated to establish a rough demographic baseline. This was done by calculating the sum of birth cohorts in Iceland from 1913 to 2006 (Statistics Iceland 2026) and assuming a 97% survival rate to age 18. The estimate yielded approximately 340.126 individuals. Of these, 1.156 served as members of parliament during the period, corresponding to an estimated parliamentary participation rate of approximately 0.34% in the general population. This is a notable difference in parliamentary entry rate and supports H1, which posits that leaders in student politics have a non-trivial probability of entering national politics through parliament.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{General Population Entry Rate} &= \frac{\text{Number of Individuals Who Served in Alþingi}}{\sum \text{Birth Cohorts}_{1913-2006} \times 0.97} \\ &= \frac{1.156}{340.126} \approx 0.0034 = 0.34\% \end{aligned}$$

As for the parliamentary entry rate dynamics by gender, student association, council, cohort, and ticket position, the results are shown in Figure 3. There are some considerable differences in entry rates between values within each variable. Female candidates enter parliament at a higher rate than their male counterparts. There is a 2.9-point difference, with female candidates at 9.8% against male candidates at 6.9%. Similarly, University Council candidates enter at a greater rate than Student Council candidates, with the former at 14.5% and the latter at 7.1%, or 6.1% when the analysis is restricted to the post-1970 period to ensure comparability, as University Council candidates were not recorded before the 1970s.

Which association students were a part of does not seem to matter much; however, candidates from Röskva and Vaka have a slightly higher entry rate than candidates from other associations or those labeled as unknown. The entry rate for candidates at the ticket position likewise does not vary much, with the notable exception of the 5th position. 1st through 4th positions have entry rates between 6.7% and 8.2%, while the 5th position has an entry rate of 3.0%.

**Figure 3. Parliamentary Entry Rates Across Student Political Characteristics**



*Source: Data compiled by author*



The temporal pattern of parliamentary entry rates across cohorts is non-linear. While the earliest cohort (1930s–1950s) has the highest entry rate at 10.1%, the middle cohort (1960s–1980s) shows a significant drop to 4.7%, and the latest cohort (1990s–2020s) shows a rise again to 8.7%.

**Table 6. Parliamentary Entry Rates Across Decades**

| <i>Decade</i> |        |
|---------------|--------|
| 1930s         | 8.93%  |
| 1940s         | 12.87% |
| 1950s         | 7.69%  |
| 1960s         | 3.77%  |
| 1970s         | 8.11%  |
| 1980s         | 3.36%  |
| 1990s         | 10.64% |
| 2000s         | 7.55%  |
| 2010s         | 8.33%  |
| 2020s         | 8.33%  |
| Total         | 7.83%  |

*Source: Data compiled by author*

This is echoed at the decade level (Table 6), where parliamentary entry rates fluctuate considerably across decades rather than declining in a consistent linear manner. While the 1930s and 1940s display relatively high entry rates, the 1960s and 1980s stand out with substantially lower rates, before parliamentary entry rises again in the 1990s and remains comparatively stable thereafter.

## 3.2 Hypothesis Testing

### 3.2.1 Council Type and Ticket Position

A logistic regression model is used to test whether these factors affect the likelihood of leaders in student politics entering parliament. However, as data on university council candidacies are available only from 1972 onward, including the variable in the main model would substantially reduce the model's temporal scope. Therefore, it is omitted, and the relationship is analyzed separately.

To test H2, which posits that parliamentary entry rates differ between candidates for the student council and the university council, a two-proportion z-test was conducted. The results, as reported above, show that the parliamentary entry rate is higher among candidates for the University Council (14.5%, 11/76) than among those for the Student Council (7.2%, 57/791), and the difference is statistically significant ( $z = 2.25$ ,  $p < 0.05$ ). These results hold when the comparison is limited to the 1970s and onward, excluding decades with no observations for University Council candidates. Entry rate remains higher among University Council candidates (14.5%, 11/76) than among Student Council candidates (6.1%, 30/490), and the difference remains significant ( $z = 2.61$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). Further analyzing this relationship, a third z-test was conducted, including only student council candidates who had taken the first position on a ticket from the 1970s onward. The results were significant ( $z = 2.02$ ,  $p < 0.05$ ), where University Council candidates retained a higher entry rate (14.5%, 11/74) than Student Council candidates (6.7%, 13/189). The null hypothesis of no difference in parliamentary entry rates by council type is rejected at  $\alpha = 0.05$ .

Ticket position is also excluded from the final model as it does not display a statistically significant or substantively meaningful relationship with parliamentary entry in the multivariable analysis, and its inclusion does not improve model fit. To test H3, which posits that the ticket

position held in the student politics elections affects subsequent parliamentary entry, we run a Cochran-Armitage trend test, a modified chi-square test for a two-value categorical variable, and an ordinal variable. The test allows us to reject the null hypothesis, as it indicates a statistically significant negative trend between ticket position and parliamentary entry ( $z = 2.10$ ,  $p < 0.05$ ), suggesting that individuals placed higher on electoral tickets are more likely to subsequently enter parliament.

### 3.2.2 Multivariable Models of Parliamentary Entry

A logistic regression model of the remaining variables was conducted to test H4, which posits that the likelihood of parliamentary entry differs across student associations; H5, that time of participation in student politics affects the likelihood of entry; and H6, that gender affects the likelihood of entry. The model assesses the relationship between the dependent variable, whether a student leader entered parliament, and the independent variables, association, cohort, and gender.

| <b>Model 1. Multivariable Logistic Regression of Parliamentary Entry</b> |              |           |                |                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----------|----------------|--------------------|
| <b>Predictor Variable</b>                                                | <b>Coef.</b> | <b>SE</b> | <b>z value</b> | <b>Pr(&gt; z )</b> |
| <i><b>Association</b></i>                                                |              |           |                |                    |
| Vaka                                                                     | —            | —         | —              | —                  |
| Röskva & predecessors                                                    | 0.434        | 0.334     | 1.299          | 0.194              |
| Unknown                                                                  | -0.223       | 0.543     | -0.411         | 0.681              |
| Other                                                                    | -0.907       | 0.418     | -2.169         | 0.030 *            |
| <i><b>Cohort</b></i>                                                     |              |           |                |                    |
| 1930s–1950s                                                              | —            | —         | —              | —                  |
| 1960s–1980s                                                              | -1.698       | 0.458     | -3.706         | 0.000 ***          |

|                                                              |        |       |        |          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------|--------|----------|
| 1990s–2020s                                                  | -1.131 | 0.432 | -2.613 | 0.009 ** |
| <b><i>Gender</i></b>                                         |        |       |        |          |
| Male                                                         | -0.494 | 0.310 | -1.594 | 0.111    |
| <hr/>                                                        |        |       |        |          |
| N = 856                                                      |        |       |        |          |
| Nagelkerke $R^2 \approx 0.046$                               |        |       |        |          |
| <hr/>                                                        |        |       |        |          |
| . $p < 0.1$ . * $p < 0.05$ . ** $p < 0.01$ . *** $p < 0.001$ |        |       |        |          |

The results indicate statistically significant differences in parliamentary entry across two of the three independent variables. Firstly, taking into account the other independent variables, both later cohorts show a significant negative relationship with the earlier comparison cohort, indicating that leaders in student politics in later cohorts are less likely to enter parliament than those in the 1930s–1950s. Specifically, the 1960s–1980s cohort has substantially lower odds of entering parliament ( $OR \approx 0.18$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), corresponding to roughly an 82% reduction relative to the reference cohort, while the 1990s–2020s cohort also shows lower odds ( $OR \approx 0.32$ ,  $p < 0.01$ ), equivalent to about a 68% reduction.

Secondly, the “Other” associations show a significant negative relationship ( $p < 0.05$ ) with the comparison association, Vaka, but the other associations do not exhibit a significant relationship. However, the negative coefficient for “Other” is not stable across cohorts and appears to be driven by its concentration in earlier decades. When restricting the sample to later cohorts, the effect disappears, indicating that the original estimate reflects temporal composition rather than a consistent association-level difference. This is further confirmed by the relationship not holding significance when temporal weights are added to the model (model 2).

As for the model fit, the models' interpretation is limited by a low Nagelkerke  $R^2$  of 0.046, indicating that the variables explain only a modest 4.6% of the variation in parliamentary

entry among the sample. Despite this, there is a discernible temporal pattern. As a robustness check, temporal weights were added to account for differences in exposure time across cohorts, with earlier cohorts having had more time to enter parliament. The results remain consistent, as seen in Model 2, suggesting that the difference is not solely driven by differences in exposure.

We cannot reject the null hypotheses for H4 and H6, as parliamentary entry does not appear to vary significantly by association or gender. However, we reject the null hypothesis for H5, as the probability of parliamentary entry varies significantly by time of participation in student politics.

**Model 2. Multivariable Logistic Regression with Temporal Exposure Weights**

| Predictor Variable                                                                                                 | Coef.  | SE    | z value | Pr(> z ) |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------|---------|----------|
| <i>Association</i>                                                                                                 |        |       |         |          |
| Vaka                                                                                                               | —      | —     | —       | —        |
| Röskva & predecessors                                                                                              | 0.469  | 0.291 | 1.606   | 0.108    |
| Unknown                                                                                                            | -0.000 | 0.281 | -1.649  | 1.000    |
| Other                                                                                                              | -0.625 | 0.495 | -1.263  | 0.207    |
| <i>Cohort</i>                                                                                                      |        |       |         |          |
| 1930s–1950s                                                                                                        | —      | —     | —       | —        |
| 1960s–1980s                                                                                                        | -1.556 | 0.511 | -3.047  | 0.002 ** |
| 1990s–2020s                                                                                                        | -0.966 | 0.470 | -2.054  | 0.040 *  |
| <i>Gender</i>                                                                                                      |        |       |         |          |
| Male                                                                                                               | -0.463 | 0.281 | -1.649  | 0.099 .  |
| <i>N</i> = 856<br>Nagelkerke $R^2 \approx 0.033$<br>Weight: 1930s-1950s = 0.5. 1960s-1980s = 1. 1990s-2020s = 1.5. |        |       |         |          |

.  $p < 0.1$ . \* $p < 0.05$ . \*\* $p < 0.01$ . \*\*\* $p < 0.001$

### 3.2.3 Timing of Parliamentary Entry

Similar results emerge from the Cox proportional hazards model (see Model 3), that we performed to test H7 that posits that earlier cohorts reach parliament more quickly than later cohorts and H8 that states that gender affects the timing of parliamentary entry. “Other” associations display a significantly lower hazard rate, meaning those individuals are less likely to enter parliament at any given time compared to the reference group, Vaka. As discussed previously, this relationship is likely partly driven by temporal composition effects.

**Model 3. Cox Regression of Timing of Parliamentary Entry**

| Predictor Variable                                    | Coef.  | HR    | 95% CI        | Pr(> z )  |
|-------------------------------------------------------|--------|-------|---------------|-----------|
| <i>Association</i>                                    |        |       |               |           |
| Vaka                                                  | —      | —     | —             | —         |
| Röskva & predecessors                                 | 0.411  | 1.508 | 0.804 - 2.825 | 0.200     |
| Unknown                                               | -0.256 | 0.774 | 0.283 - 2.113 | 0.617     |
| Other                                                 | -0.907 | 0.404 | 0.188 - 0.869 | 0.020 *   |
| <i>Cohort</i>                                         |        |       |               |           |
| 1930s–1950s                                           | —      | —     | —             | —         |
| 1960s–1980s                                           | -1.657 | 0.191 | 0.081 - 0.448 | 0.000 *** |
| 1990s–2020s                                           | -0.629 | 0.533 | 0.239 - 1.187 | 0.124     |
| <i>Gender</i>                                         |        |       |               |           |
| Male                                                  | -0.525 | 0.592 | 0.332 - 1.054 | 0.075 .   |
| Concordance = 0.675                                   |        |       |               |           |
| Likelihood ratio $\chi^2 = 24.36$ (df = 6, p < 0.001) |        |       |               |           |
| N = 856, Events = 67                                  |        |       |               |           |

. p < 0.1. \*p < 0.05. \*\*p < 0.01. \*\*\*p < 0.001

Cohort effects remain strong in the survival models. The 1960s–1980s cohort shows a substantially lower hazard of parliamentary entry than the 1930s–1950s cohort ( $HR = 0.191$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ), indicating a much slower or less likely transition to parliament. While the 1990s–2020s cohort also displays a lower hazard rate, though the effect is not statistically significant ( $HR = 0.533$ ,  $p > 0.05$ ). Thus, we can partially reject the null hypothesis of no difference in parliamentary entry time by time of participation in student politics.

Gender, unlike in the previous models, shows a marginally significant relationship ( $HR = 0.592$ ,  $p < 0.1$ ), with males having a lower hazard, suggesting slower parliamentary entry. However, the relationship is not strong enough for us to reject the null hypothesis.

## 4 Discussions

Even under conservative assumptions, parliamentary entry is substantially more common among student politicians than the general public, establishing the existence of a political pathway from leaders in student politics at the UI to national politics. The 7.8% of the sample who later became MPs is significantly higher than the 0.34% parliamentary entry rate in the general population. It is, however, shadowed by the whopping 19% of British parliamentarians in 2011 who reported engaging in student politics (Durose et al. 2011). While roughly measuring the same phenomenon, the operationalization in this study differs greatly from that of the Equality and Human Rights Commission (EHRC) in the UK, where MPs were asked whether they had “been active in student politics” prior to being elected. This is wording that allows for methods of participation outside the strict criteria for leadership in student politics used in this study. Similarly, the EHRC's sample was politicians, while this study collected information on leaders in student politics. Proportions of student leaders who end up in parliament are conceptually different from the proportions of MPs who have participated in student politics.

The proportional entry rates vary by a couple of factors, but are dominated by a cohort effect where those belonging to the earliest cohort (1930s-1950s) were the most likely to subsequently have a parliamentary career. While we would expect a linear trend where a consistent decline in parliamentary entry would be attributed to progressively less exposure (time to enter parliament), and to an extent, a disruption in elite circulation. Higher education had, during the period of analysis, become more accessible, which in turn would suggest that the student body gradually became less elite and more diverse in terms of background. Under these assumptions, we would expect a consistent decline in parliamentary entry rates. However, this



was not the case. Rather, the middle cohort (1960s-1980s) disrupts the trend, with a significant drop in entry rates before it picked up again for the latest cohort (1990s-2020s).

Examining this drop at the decade level, we see that the 1970s had an entry rate of 8.11%, consistent with the range observed between the 1930s and 2020s, while the other two decades comprising the middle cohort, the 1960s and 1980s, had a much lower entry rate at 3.77% and 3.36%, respectively. In this context, it is important to note the institutional changes that occurred in student politics at the UI during that time. As mentioned before, the 1960s were a time of individual candidate voting, a move away from association-based ticket voting in an effort to divert student politics from ideologically based discourse on local and global issues and towards issues pertaining to the student body. This institutional change may have altered the extent to which student politics served as a site for acquiring skills and experience, suggesting that organized campaigning around tickets (ideologies) played a role in facilitating pathways into national politics. This interpretation is, however, difficult to reconcile with the 1980s displaying an even lower entry rate despite the reintroduction of ticket voting.

Not only does the cohort display a lower parliamentary entry rate, but individuals belonging to the cohort who eventually enter parliament tend to do so later than those in the earliest cohort, reflected in a substantially lower hazard of parliamentary entry.

While we observe a strong cohort effect, other variables, such as gender and the student association represented, do not seem to have an effect on parliamentary entry. Initially, results displayed a significant relationship between those who were in “other” associations with the reference association Vaka. However, after further examination, we can determine that this relationship was driven by the aforementioned cohort effect, with “other” associations being dominant in the earliest cohort and negligible in the other two. Associations do not differ in

subsequent parliamentary careers of their members, but they may differ in other ways outside the scope of this current study, e.g., which political parties they enter in parliament. As the criticism of the association-based ticket system was articulated by Höskuldur Jónsson (1959), “the top positions are often occupied by presumptuous flibbertigibbets who only work as ambassadors for political parties and whose sole goal is to force their political views on students.” While polemical, the statement suggests two things: that student associations are political outside the bounds of university life, and that higher-ticket positions may have carried greater political visibility, organizational centrality, or symbolic importance within student politics.

The sample is limited to the top five ticket positions for each association, but statistical testing provides evidence of higher parliamentary entry rates for those occupying higher positions. Rates for the top four positions decline minimally; however, a large drop is observed from the fourth (7.4%) to the fifth position (3.0%), which may hint at a possible cutoff, with the pathway established largely confined to those occupying the top four positions.

This hierarchy may have been especially pronounced within the University Council elections, where those elected have a seat at the table with the Rector and other top university administrators. The top ticket positions (often just one candidate per association) are thus likely among the most selective and institutionally prestigious roles available within student politics. Thus, it is not surprising that there is more than a 6-point difference in the entry rate between Student and University Council candidates.

Overall, the study finds that student politics at the University of Iceland constituted a meaningful pathway into parliament during the period of analysis, although the strength and dynamics of that pathway varied by ticket position, council candidacy, and, most notably, across historical cohorts.

## **5 Limitations and Next Steps**

While the study is limited to one country, it provides insight into the dynamics of political career pathways that could be cautiously applied to a broader context. Acknowledging the potential self-selection process in which individuals who enter student politics may already be more likely to pursue parliamentary careers, the magnitude of the pathway identified in this study suggests that the accumulation of politically relevant resources, experience, and networks developed through participation may facilitate a career for politically ambitious individuals.

Constrained by time and data access, the study's scope was limited to those considered leaders in student politics. Further exploration of this topic could include adding to the dataset collected for this study, potentially new background variables (educational attainment and class), or broadening the inclusion criteria to include those who participate in student politics to a lesser extent. With the latter creating a natural comparison group (leaders vs participants).

Other avenues of exploration include examining the proportion of current MPs who participated in student politics (similar to the EHRC report) or, perhaps more interesting, conducting a study of a group of participants in student politics in which political interest and ambition, and resource and skill accumulation, are measured. The latter would especially strengthen the results of this study, were it to confirm the assumptions on which it is based.

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